BUSINESS MODEL DEVELOPMENT

Report On:

SwaadBox – A Hyperlocal Homemade Food Marketplace

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Objective :To identify a market pain point, develop a sustainable business model using the Business Model Canvas (BMC), and execute a digital prototype (Web Application).

Phase 1: Problem Identification & Ideation

Introduction

In today's fast-paced urban environment, students, working professionals, and people away from home face a persistent challenge — finding healthy, affordable, and home-cooked food on a daily basis. Most available options are either expensive restaurant meals, unhealthy fast food, or inconvenient canteen food that lacks the taste and nutrition of homemade cooking.

SwaadBox addresses this gap by creating a hyperlocal digital marketplace that connects home chefs — individuals who cook fresh, homemade meals — with consumers who crave nutritious, affordable, and familiar food. This report explores the business model development process behind SwaadBox, from identifying the pain point to building a viable product strategy.

Activity 01: Problem Identification

Pain Point Analysis

The current food ecosystem for students and working professionals presents several critical challenges for both consumers and potential home-based food providers. The key issues identified are as follows:

- **Lack of Healthy Options:** Students and working professionals struggle to get healthy, home-cooked food affordably and conveniently.
- **High Cost:** Restaurant and fast food is expensive on a daily basis, making it financially unsustainable for students.
- **Poor Quality & Taste:** Packaged and outside food lacks the taste, variety, and nutritional value of home-cooked meals.
- **Untapped Home Chef Talent:** Home cooks with culinary skills have no structured platform to monetize their cooking talent.
- **No Trusted Discovery Channel:** Consumers have no way to discover or trust local home-food providers without a reliable platform.
- **Absence of Hyperlocal Food Network:** There is no platform enabling direct connections between home chefs and nearby hungry consumers.

The primary target audience affected by these issues includes hostel students, day-scholar students, working professionals, and home cooks looking to generate income from their cooking skills.

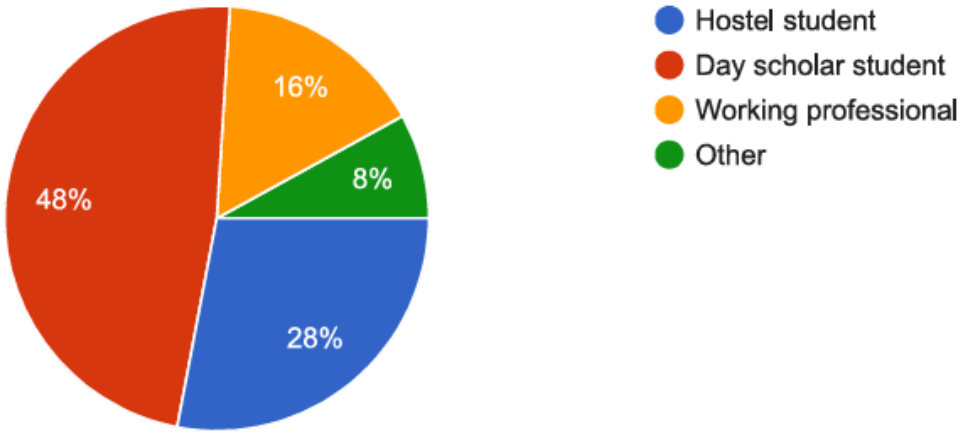
Market Survey

Primary Research

A survey was conducted among 25 respondents to understand their food consumption habits, preferences, pain points, and willingness to adopt a homemade tiffin food service. The findings are presented below:

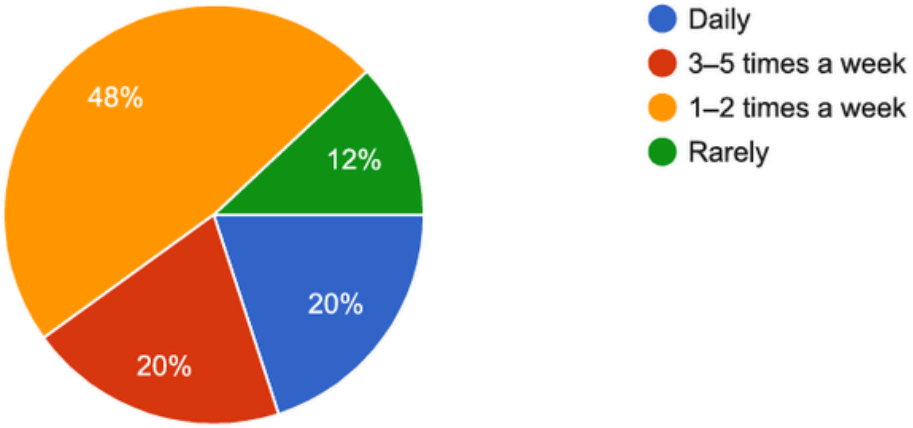
Q1. What best describes you?

25 responses



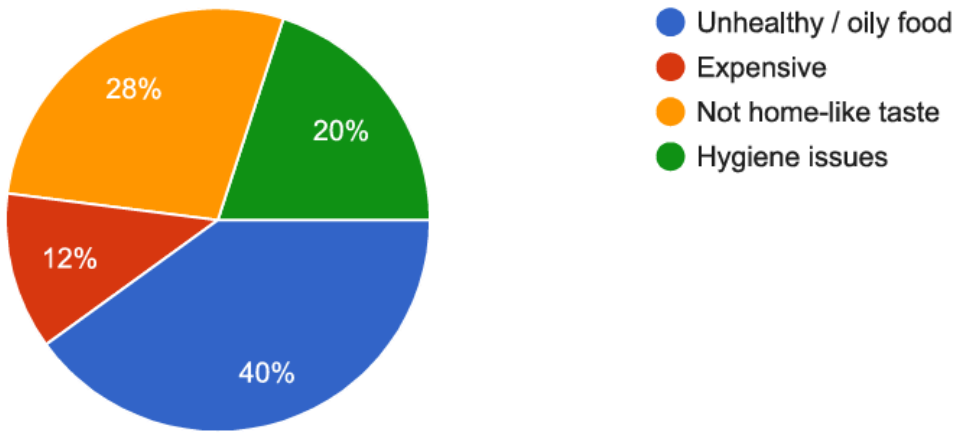
Q2. How often do you eat outside food (restaurant / fast food)?

25 responses



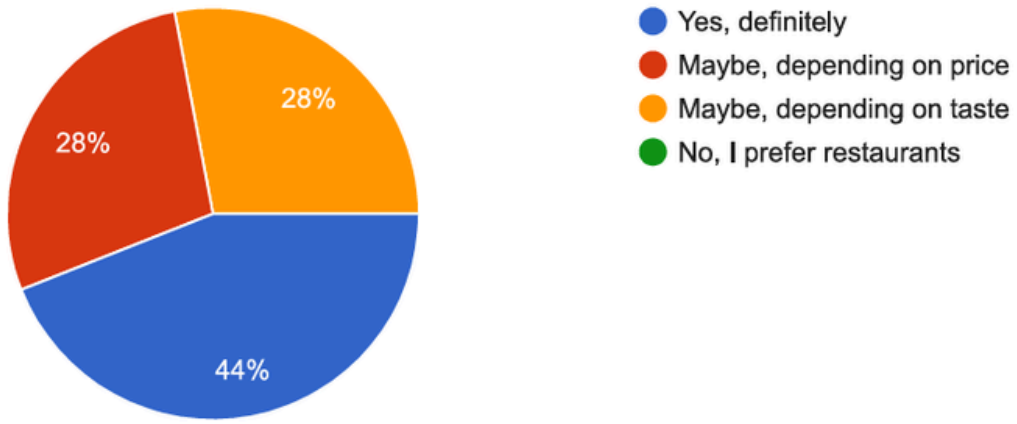
Q3. What is your biggest problem with current food options?

25 responses



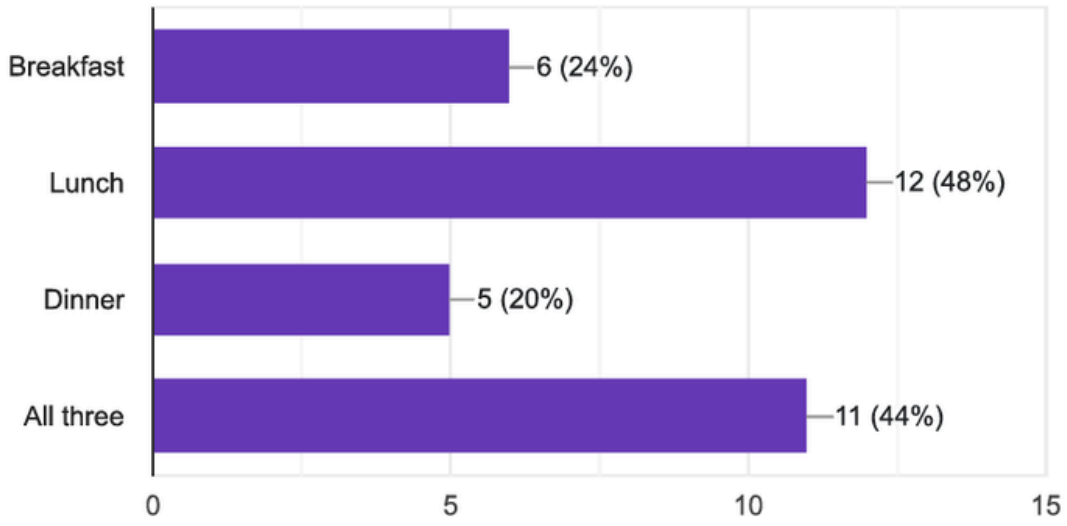
Q4. Would you prefer homemade tiffin food over restaurant food?

25 responses



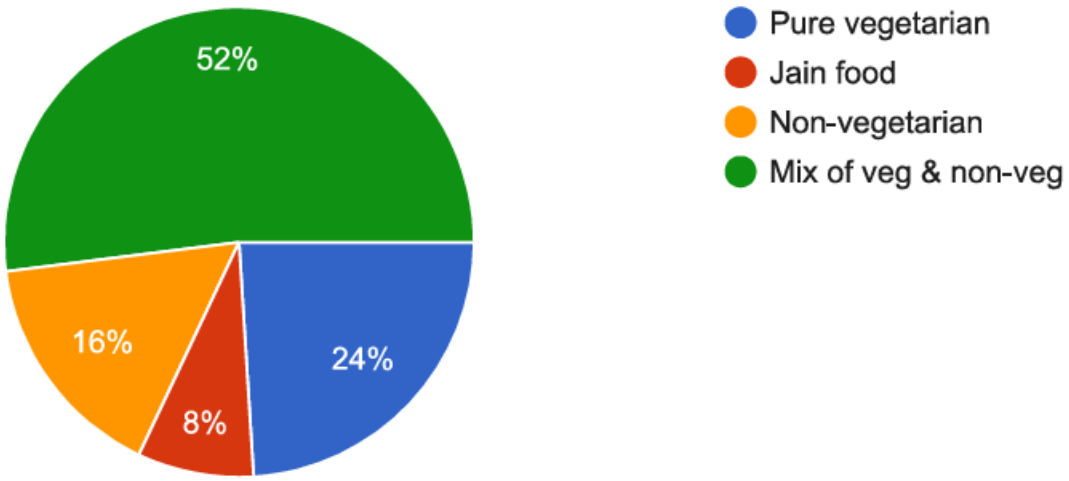
Q5. Which meals would you be interested in?

25 responses



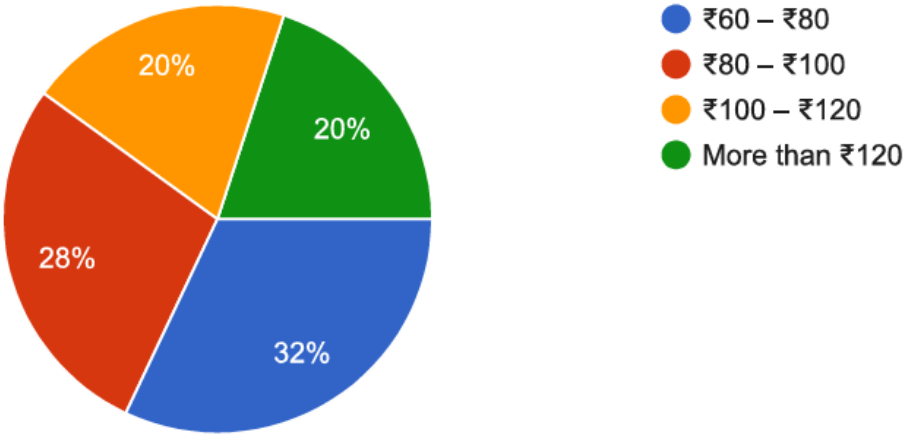
Q6. What type of food do you prefer?

25 responses



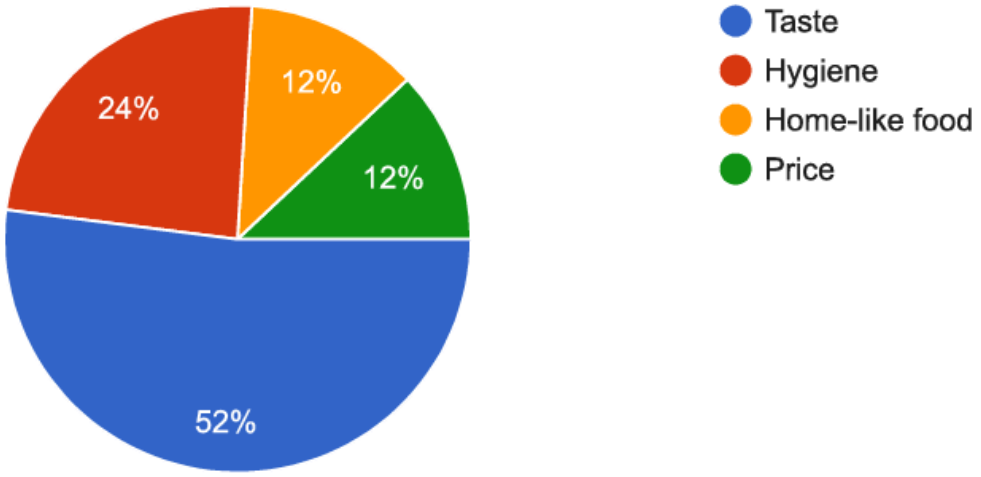
Q7. How much are you willing to pay per meal?

25 responses



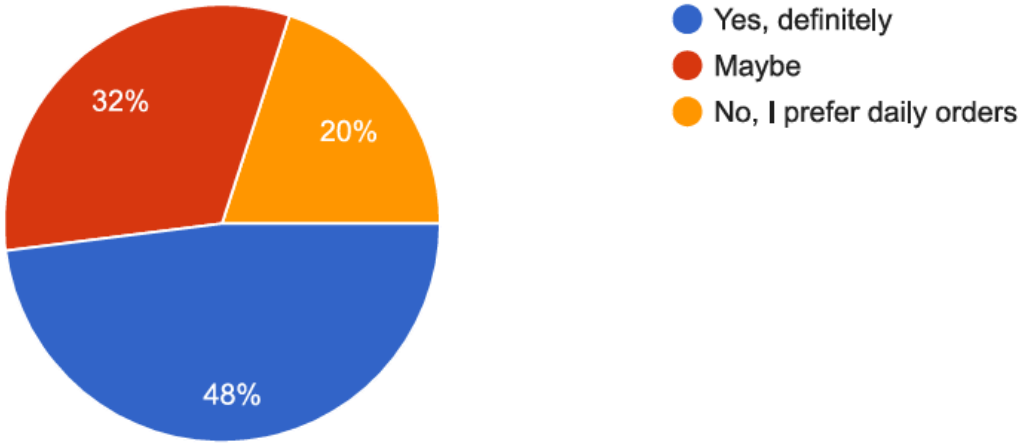
Q8. How important are these factors for you?

25 responses



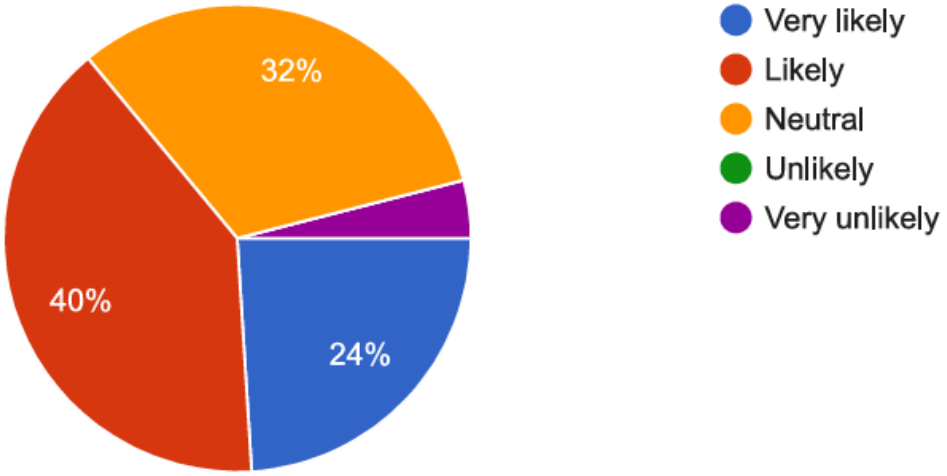
Q9. Would you prefer a monthly tiffin subscription?

25 responses



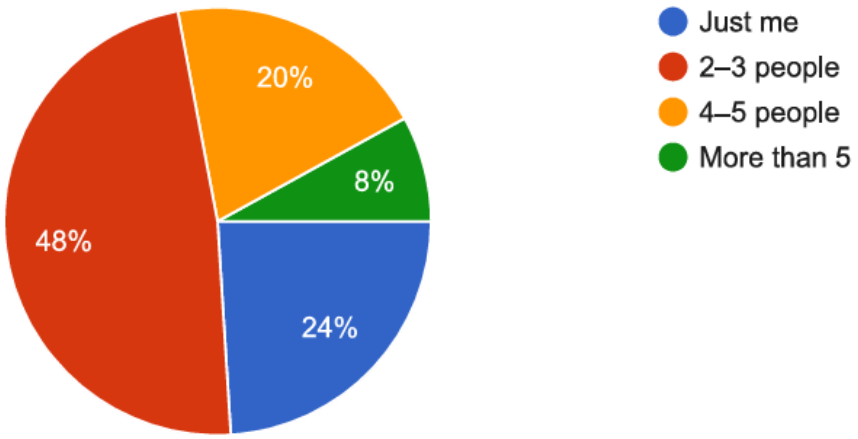
Q10. If this service is available near you, how likely are you to try it?

25 responses



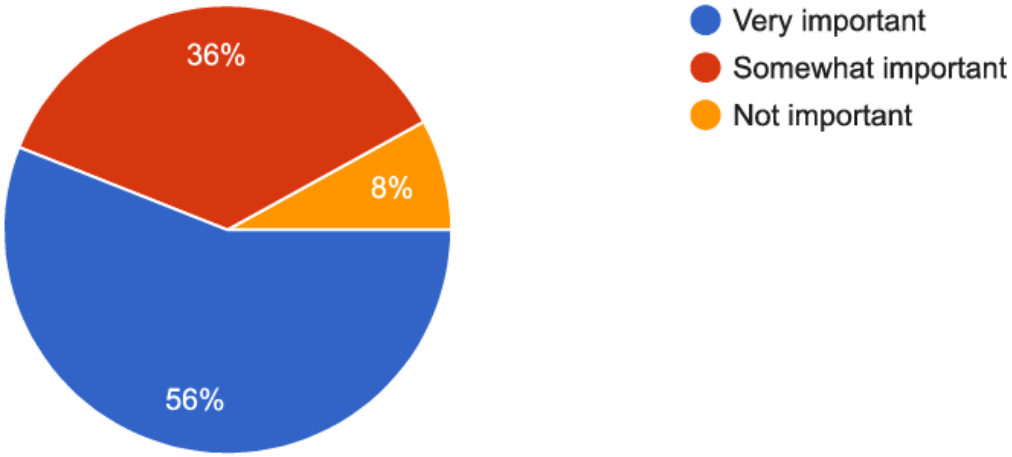
Q11. How many people around you would also be interested?

25 responses

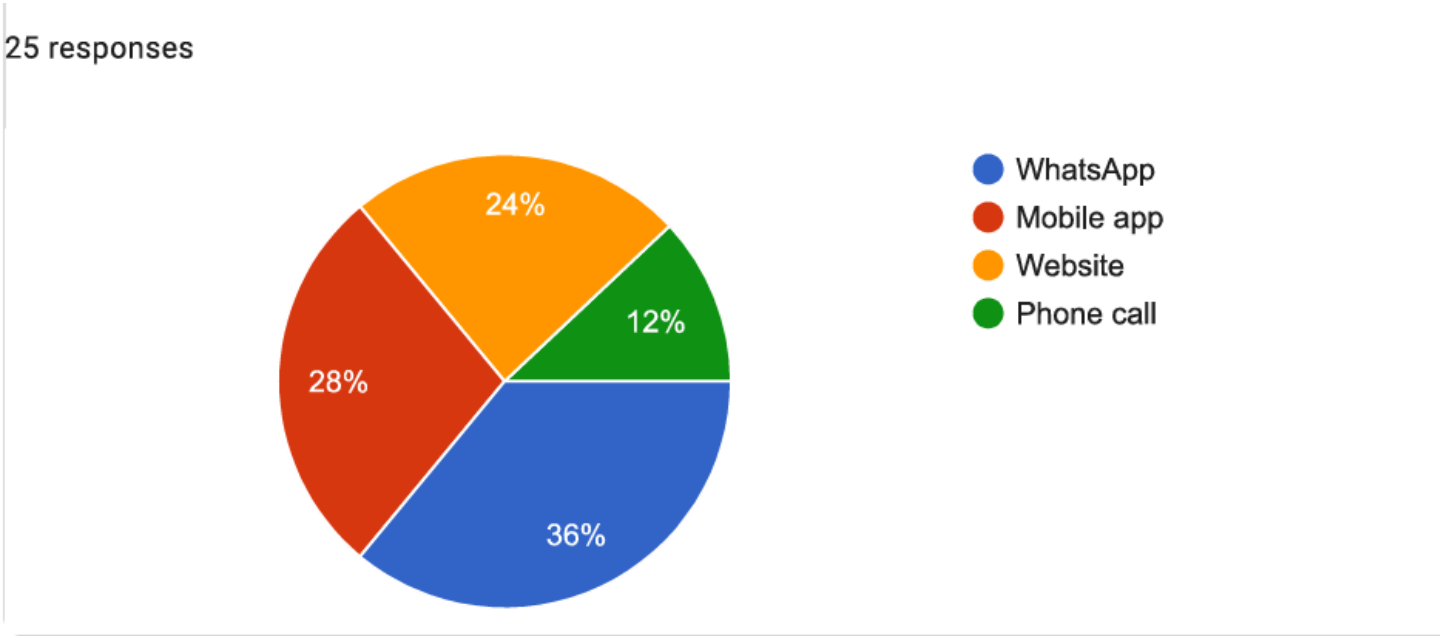


Q12. How important is daily menu variety for you?

25 responses



Q13. How would you prefer to place orders?



Secondary Research

Secondary research indicates a growing trend toward homemade and healthy food consumption, especially among urban youth and the working population. Key observations include:

- The Indian home-cooked food delivery market is growing rapidly, driven by health awareness post-pandemic.
- Rising adoption of mobile-based food ordering applications has lowered the barrier to entry for food marketplaces.
- Demand for regional, home-style food is increasing as more students and professionals move to metro cities.
- Home-based food businesses have seen a significant rise, with platforms like Instagram and WhatsApp being used informally.
- The gig economy is empowering home cooks to explore micro-entrepreneurship, creating a ready supply of providers.

These trends strongly support the need for a structured, digital platform like SwaadBox to formalize and scale the informal home food economy.

Activity 02: Design a Digital Solution

Ideation Techniques

Brainstorming and Mind Mapping

Various ideas were generated to address the identified problem, including:

- A hyperlocal food discovery app showing nearby home chefs
- A subscription-based tiffin delivery platform
- A community-driven home food marketplace with ratings
- An admin-controlled quality assurance system for food providers
- A WhatsApp-integrated ordering system for home cooks

SCAMPER Analysis

The SCAMPER technique was used to refine and improve the initial ideas:

- **Substitute:** Replace restaurant food ordering with home chef discovery and ordering
- **Combine:** Integrate chef registration, menu management, order tracking, and earnings in one platform
- **Adapt:** Use city-based filtering similar to hyperlocal delivery apps like Swiggy for home food
- **Modify:** Enhance with admin-controlled chef approval for quality control and platform trust
- **Put to Another Use:** Apply the platform model across hostels, PGs, and corporate cafeterias
- **Eliminate:** Remove dependency on large restaurant kitchens — empower individuals to cook from home
- **Rearrange:** Allow pre-scheduling of meals and reordering of favourite past meals

Final Solution Selection

Based on feasibility, scalability, and market demand, the selected solution is:

"SwaadBox – A Hyperlocal Homemade Food Marketplace"

Key Features

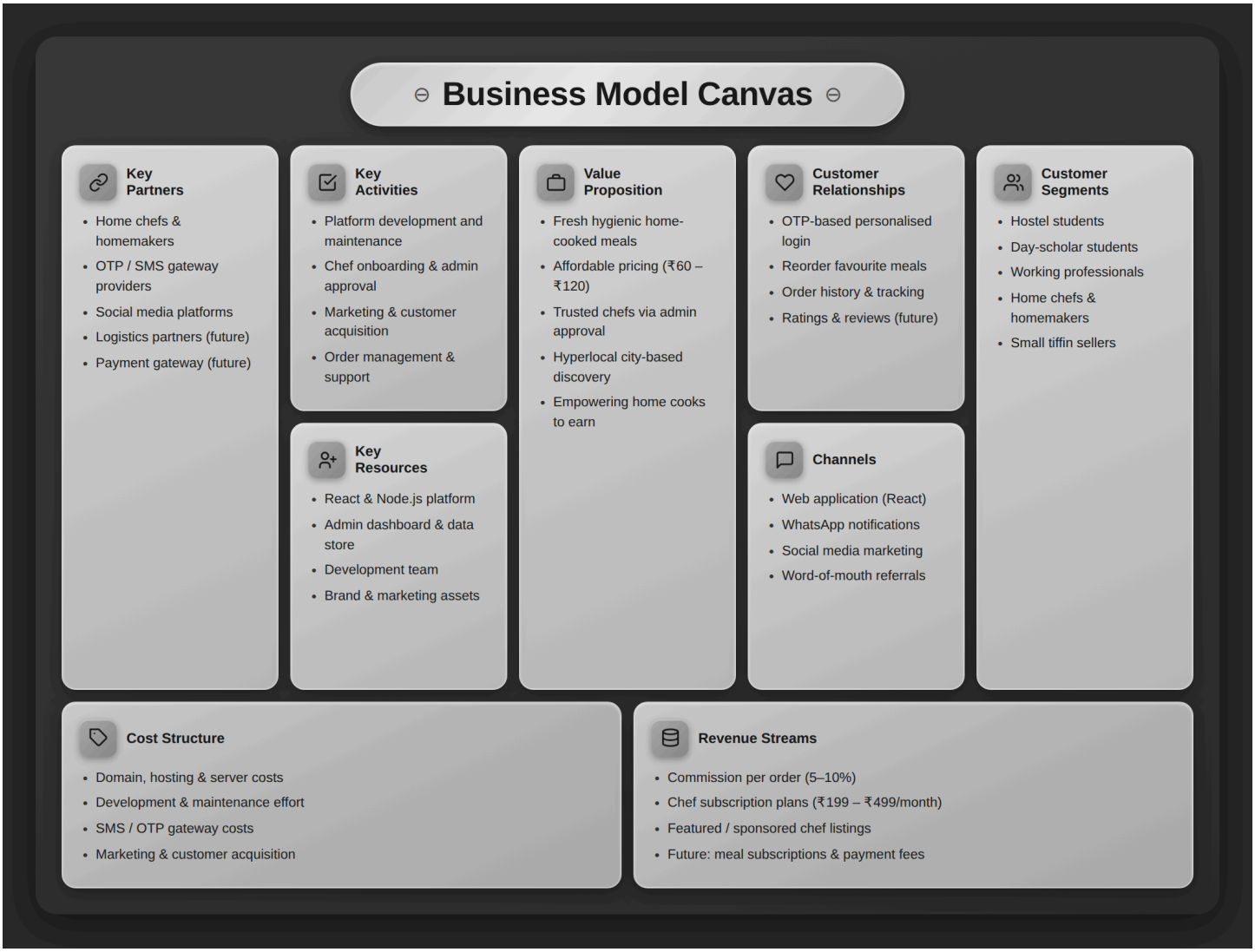
- OTP-based user authentication for secure access
- City-based filtering to discover local home chefs
- Browse provider menus with dish name, price, and description
- End-to-end order placement and tracking
- Home chef registration and dashboard with menu management
- Admin approval workflow to maintain quality control
- Earnings tracking for home chef providers
- Reorder favourite meals from past orders

Justification of the Solution

- **Market Demand:** Survey shows 44% users would definitely prefer homemade tiffin over restaurant food
- **Technical Feasibility:** Built on React + Node.js + Express — proven, widely adopted tech stack
- **Scalability:** City-based filtering model easily expandable to multiple cities and regions
- **User Convenience:** Eliminates need to search informally for home food via WhatsApp or word-of-mouth
- **Social Impact:** Empowers home cooks (especially women) to monetize cooking skills and earn income

Phase 2: Developing the Business Model Canvas (BMC)

Business Model Canvas



Activity 03: Infrastructure & Value

Value Proposition

SwaadBox provides a unique and trusted solution to the daily food problem for students and working professionals by connecting them directly with verified home chefs in their city. The core value offerings are:

- **Affordable Home Food:** Students and professionals can order fresh, home-cooked meals at affordable prices without relying on restaurants.

- **Hyperlocal Discovery:** Users can browse nearby home chefs filtered by city, making discovery simple and local.
- **Quality & Trust:** Admin approval ensures every chef on the platform is verified, building trust among consumers.
- **Chef Empowerment:** Home cooks can register, add menus, toggle availability, and track their earnings all from one dashboard.
- **Simple User Experience:** The platform provides a clean, card-based interface for smooth browsing and ordering experience.

Activity 04: Customer Interaction

Customer Segments

The success of the SwaadBox platform depends on clearly identifying its target users. The primary customer segments include:

- **Hostel & Day-Scholar Students:** Students living in hostels and PGs who need affordable, healthy daily meals and miss home-cooked food.
- **Urban Working Professionals:** Professionals seeking hygienic, home-style food near their workplace as an alternative to canteen or restaurant meals.
- **Home Cooks & Micro-Entrepreneurs:** Home cooks — often homemakers — who want to monetize their cooking skills and earn from home with flexible hours.
- **People Away from Home:** Individuals who have relocated away from their hometowns and crave regional, home-style cuisine.

Customer Relationships

The platform establishes and maintains relationships with users through the following methods:

- **Reorder Convenience:** Users can easily reorder their favourite past meals, reducing friction in repeat purchases.
- **Secure & Simple Authentication:** OTP-based login ensures secure and frictionless access without the need for passwords.
- **Admin Support Layer:** The admin dashboard provides a responsive support layer to handle chef approvals, disputes, and platform issues.
- **Real-time Order Management for Chefs:** Home chefs receive real-time order notifications and can toggle availability to manage workload.
- **Future Personalization:** Future implementation of ratings, reviews, and AI meal recommendations will personalize the experience further.

Activity 05: Financial Viability

Fixed Costs (Initial Setup & Monthly Fixed Expenses)

A. Initial Setup Cost (One-Time)

- Domain Name: ₹800 – ₹1,000 per year
- UI/UX Design Tools (if paid): ₹1,500 – ₹2,000
- Testing & Miscellaneous Expenses: ₹2,000

Total Initial Cost: ₹4,500 – ₹5,000

B. Monthly Fixed Costs

- Cloud Hosting (Firebase / Render / AWS Free Tier with upgrades): ₹1,000 – ₹2,000/month
- Database Services: Included in hosting (or minimal ₹500 if scaled)

Total Monthly Fixed Cost: ₹1,500 – ₹2,500/month

C. Variable Costs

- OTP/SMS Services (optional — free push notifications can substitute): ₹500 – ₹1,000/month
- Social Media Marketing & Promotions: ₹1,000 – ₹1,500/month

Total Variable Cost: ₹1,500 – ₹2,500/month

D. Total Estimated Cost

- Initial Investment: ₹5,000 (approx.)
- Monthly Operational Cost: ₹3,000 – ₹5,000

Revenue Streams

A. Commission-Based Model (Primary)

SwaadBox charges a small commission on every order placed through the platform.

- 5–10% commission per order from home chefs

Example: If 500 orders/month at average ₹100 value:

→ **₹2,500 – ₹5,000/month (at 5–10% commission)**

B. Subscription Model (For Home Chefs)

Home chefs can subscribe to premium plans for enhanced visibility and features.

- Basic Plan: ₹199/month — standard listing
- Premium Plan: ₹499/month — featured listing, analytics, priority orders

Example: If 20 chefs subscribe at ₹199:

→ **₹3,980/month**

C. Featured Listing & Promotions

- Home chefs can pay to be featured prominently on the platform for better visibility
- Banner ads or sponsored listings: ₹1,000 – ₹2,000/month (initial stage)

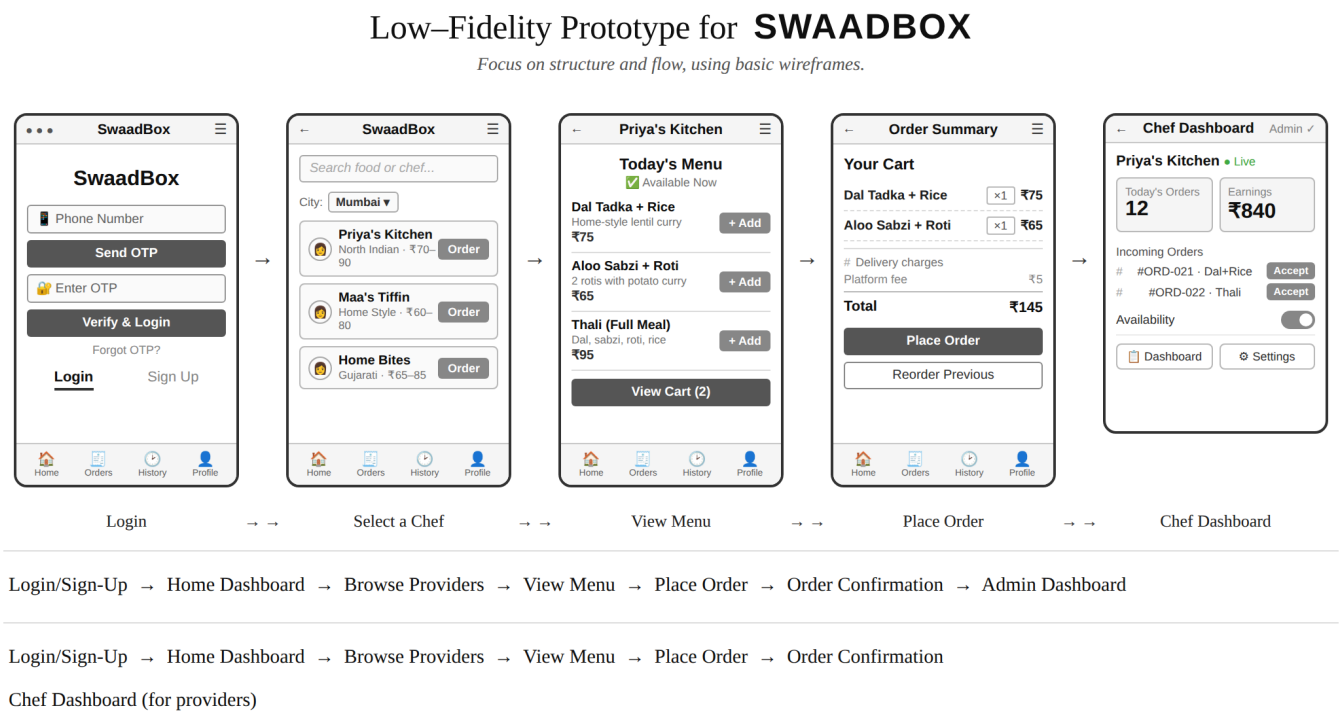
D. Future Revenue Scope

- Online payment integration with processing fees
- Monthly tiffin subscription packages sold directly to consumers
- AI-based meal recommendation engine (premium feature)
- White-label platform for college canteens and hostels
- Partnerships with PG aggregators and co-working spaces

Phase 3: Prototype Development

Activity 06: Low-Fidelity Prototyping

A low-fidelity prototype was developed for SwaadBox to visualize the user journey and system flows across all three user roles: Customer, Home Chef (Provider), and Admin. The focus was on structure, navigation flow, and feature placement rather than visual design.



Activity 07: Customer Feedback

1. Introduction

Customer feedback is a crucial step in the design process, where the low-fidelity prototype of SwaadBox was tested with potential users. The goal of this activity was to evaluate usability, identify friction points, and improve the overall user experience before actual development begins.

2. Process Followed

The feedback process was conducted using a Think-Aloud Protocol, where users were asked to interact with the prototype and verbally express their thoughts while performing tasks.

Steps Involved:

1. Selected a group of target users — hostel students and working individuals
2. Provided them with the low-fidelity prototype (wireframes)
3. Assigned simple tasks such as logging in, browsing chefs, placing an order
4. Asked users to speak their thoughts while navigating
5. Observed their behavior and noted difficulties and positive reactions

3. Tasks Given to Users

- Sign up or log in using OTP
- Select a city and browse nearby home chefs
- Open a chef's profile and view their menu
- Place an order for a meal
- View order history and attempt a reorder
- Navigate back to home and explore another chef

4. Key Observations

During testing, the following insights were gathered:

- Users found the city-based filtering concept very intuitive and relevant
- Card-based UI for chef browsing was appreciated for its simplicity
- The OTP login was seen as secure but users wanted a faster flow
- Menu display with price and description was clear and well-received
- The reorder feature was considered very useful by frequent users
- Admin approval concept built confidence and trust in the platform

5. Identified Friction Points

- OTP flow had too many steps — users wanted one-tap verification
- Chef availability toggle was not immediately visible on the browsing screen
- Earnings section in chef dashboard lacked clarity on calculation method
- No visual indicator for pending approval status on chef registration screen
- Mobile responsiveness needed attention for smaller screen sizes

6. Improvements Suggested

Based on feedback, the following improvements were proposed:

- Streamline the OTP login to reduce steps and improve speed
- Add availability badge directly on chef cards in browse view
- Include a clear earnings breakdown (per order, weekly, monthly) in chef dashboard
- Add a status tracker on chef registration page showing approval progress
- Improve mobile responsiveness and button sizing for touch interactions
- Introduce an onboarding tutorial for first-time users

7. Outcome

The customer feedback process helped in:

- Identifying usability issues early in the design stage
- Refining the interface before entering actual development
- Increasing confidence that the product addresses real user needs
- Aligning feature priorities with actual user expectations
- Reducing potential rework and development errors in later stages

SwaadBox – Bringing the taste of home, to your doorstep.